



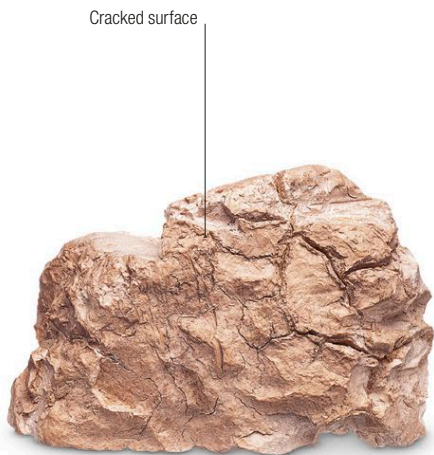
Sepiolite

△ **Rough specimen** of sepiolite (meerschaum)

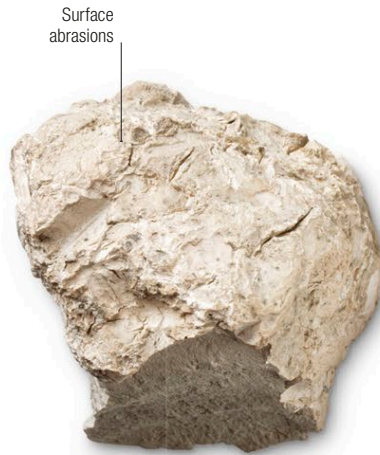
Sepiolite is perhaps best known by its popular name – meerschaum, from the German for “sea foam”. It is compact, earthy, clay-like, and often porous. Because it is usually found in nodular masses of interlocking fibres, it has a toughness that belies its mineralogical softness. This allows it to be intricately carved, most often in the form of smoking pipes. Meerschaum sepiolite is soft when first extracted and easily carved, but hardens on drying. The most important commercial sepiolite deposit is near Eskişehir, Turkey, where it is found as irregular nodules.

Specification

Chemical name Magnesium silicate hydrate
Formula $Mg_4Si_6O_{15}(OH)_2 \cdot 6H_2O$ | **Colours** White, grey, pinkish
Structure Orthorhombic | **Hardness** 2–2.5 | **SG** 2.1–2.3
RI Opaque | **Lustre** Dull to earthy | **Streak** White
Locations Turkey, USA, Italy, Czech Republic, Spain



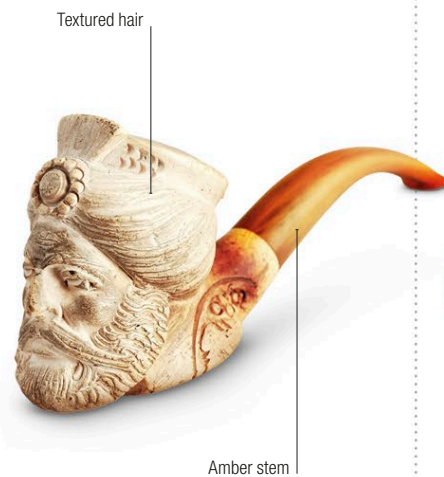
Sepiolite rough | Rough | This sepiolite (meerschaum) specimen reveals a compact surface made up of microscopic needles that form a light material able to float on water.



Meerschaum rough | Rough | The compact, clay-like nature of light and porous meerschaum (sepiolite) can be seen in this specimen of grey rough.



Meerschaum beads | Carved | Although meerschaum is mainly carved into pipes, it can be made into virtually anything, including jewellery, as these fine beads attest.



Meerschaum pipe | Carved | Intricately carved with the head of a bearded gentleman wearing a turban, this classic meerschaum pipe has a pipestem made from amber.



Cigar holder | Carved | This elaborately crafted cigar holder with claw feet and silver fittings is a fine example of meerschaum carving. A porous mineral, meerschaum develops a delicate brown patina over time.